

LITERARY CRITICISM

Literary criticism is the study, discussion, evaluation, and interpretation of literature.

Literary Theory. The capacity to generalize about phenomena and to develop concepts that form the basis for interpretation and analysis—in this instance, of a “literary” text.

Types of Literary Theory

1. Formalism has the advantage of forcing writers to evaluate a work on its own terms rather than to rely on “accepted” notions of the writer’s work. It works best when applied to poetry and short fiction. Attempts to discover meaning by close reading of a work of literature.

Focus is on:

Form, organization, and structure

Word choice and language

Multiple meanings

Considers the work in isolation, disregarding author’s intent, author’s background, context, and anything else outside of the work itself.

2. New Criticism varied from formalism in that New Criticism focuses on image, symbol, and meaning.

Features of new criticism

Meaning resides in the text—not in reader, author, or world

Texts may contain numerous messages, but must have a unifying central theme created by the perfect union of all artistic elements.

Texts are artistic creations

Close reading is the basis of new critical analysis

The methodology for finding meaning is clear-cut; the tools are unique to literary analysis

3. Reader-Response Criticism.

Features

Text has many interpretations—text & reader interact to create meaning

Meaning ultimately resides in the reader’s mind or the consensual “mind” of a community of readers

A text’s truth is relative

Readers may reach the same conclusions about a work—but approach the task quite differently

4. Reader-Response/Reception Theory is applied to the general reading public rather than an individual reader.

Features

Each generation has different experiences, values, issues, etc.

Therefore, each generation will read a work differently.

5. Structuralism.

Meaning resides in the structure of language, not in art nor in the reader’s mind

Scientific approach to literary analysis: structure of language as a logical sign system determines

meaning

Two levels of language: langue ("the King's English") & parole (everyday speech)

Interpret a text or part of a text by taking its language apart (study word derivations, sentence syntax, etc.)

6. Sociological Criticism. Maintains that the literary work cannot be separated from the social context in which it was created.

Two Aspects

Conditions of production, such as schools, magazines, publishers, and fashions.

The applicability of a given work—fiction especially—in studying the dynamics of a given society.

Two dominant theories

Feminist criticism

Marxist criticism

7. New Historicism. New historicist critics view literature as part of history, and furthermore, as an expression of forces on history.

Two Forms

Analysis of the work in the context in which it was created

Analysis of the work in the context in which it was critically evaluated.

8. Psychoanalytic Criticism

Features

Analyzes literature to reveal insights about the way the human mind works.

Is based on the work of Sigmund Freud and his disciples.

Works well as a method of analyzing characters' actions and motivations.

9. Mythological Approach

Largely attributed to Carl Jung, a disciple of Sigmund Freud

Archetype: a model or pattern from which all other things of a similar nature are made